Content Design

GIVING USERS WHAT THEY NEED,
WHEN AND HOW THEY NEED IT

1

The Website Owner's Manual

CANVA VERSION

A customisable guide for creating an effective online identity.

Supporting Resources:

Website Copy & Structure

Website Whiteboard

LEARN MORE

Your Brand Name

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Preface

The Website Owner's Manual is a project management tool. A hub for strategic planning, brand assets, and resources.

Its job is to give owners control over the legal, technical, and business responsibilities they inherit with website ownership.

It does this by providing an ordered checklist of standards to follow.

STANDARDS

Inclusive Design	-	Designing for all.
Content Design	-	Meeting needs.
Web Standards	-	Building resilience.
Agile Development	-	Being adaptable.
IndieWeb	-	Taking control.

These are links to short explainer articles on the approach used.

LEARN MORE

Principles

Business

- Problem before product.
- Justification before dependencies.
- Local skills before global platforms.
- Simplicity before automation.

Design

- Content before design.
- User needs before stakeholder ego.
- Objectives before personal taste.

Web

- Fluid before fixed units.
- Mobile before desktop.
- Semantics before styling.
- Performance before bloat.
- Accessibility before complexity.

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Road Map

Content: The mission and message that's converted into semantic HTML and made accessible to all people and devices.

Technology: What is necessary to deliver the message whilst employing the rule of least power.

Style: Visuals that objectivley improves usability and forges an emotional connection with the target audience.

Progress: The plan for inevitable change and how to evolve and improve.

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1 **Content**
Foundation & Strategy
Content & Voice

2 **Style**
Visual Identity
Image & Media

3 **Technology**
Web Components
SEO & Discoverability
Developer Specifications

4 **Progress**
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Testing & Tracking
Governance

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CONTENT

Foundation & Strategy

Who are we and why should anyone care?

Brand Purpose & Vision
Why the business exists. Core values and aims. Emotions it envokes.

Target Audience
Personas. Demographics. Visitor behaviour and challenges.

Market Position Statement
Where you sit and what you stand for. Brand promise.

SEO Strategy
Domain Name. Achievable traffic. Content gaps. Keyword competition. Search intent. EEAT (Experience, Expertise, Authoritativeness, and Trustworthiness).

Competitor Analysis
Competitors' strengths and weaknesses. Differentiation opportunities.

Content Design
What users actually need.

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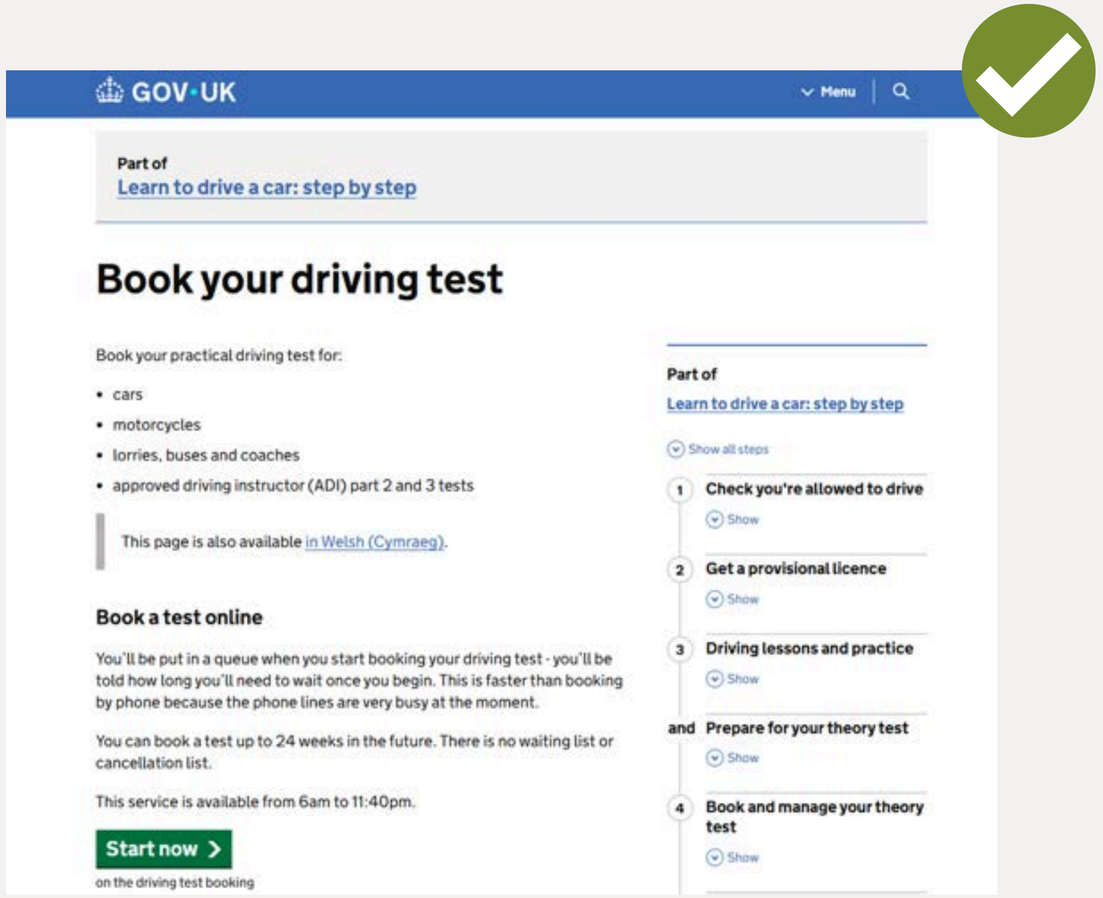
Content Design...

- Is a discipline created by Sarah Richards (now Winters) while transforming GOV.UK from hundreds government websites into a single resource.
- Has been adopted by other governments such as the US, Australia and New Zealand.
- Meta (Facebook) formally switched to content design, embedding content designers across every product team.
- Companies like Shopify, Atlassian, Apple, Google and Microsoft have followed.

Sarah Winters

No recipes, but cheaper driving tests



A different way of thinking

- Content is not written first and designed second - both happen together, shaped by evidence.
- The format (words, video, a tool, a table, nothing at all) is a design decision, not a default.
- The goal is to meet a genuine user need, not to fill a page or promote the organisation.

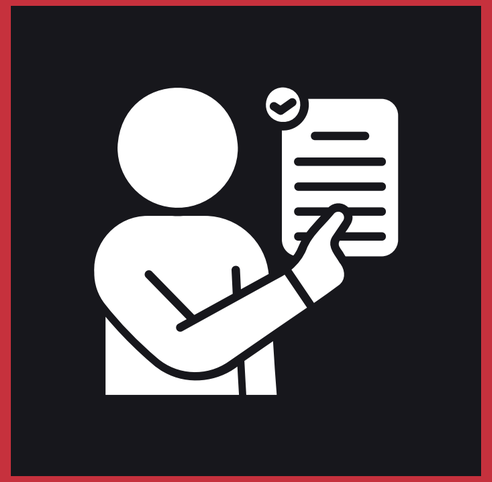
Why it matters

Most websites are written inside out - reflecting what the organisation wants to say. Content design flips that and starts with what users are actually trying to do. So...

- We create content because there is a real user need for it, not because it feels like something we should have.
- We choose the right format for the job, whether that is a short paragraph, a list, a video, or a single direct answer.
- We treat content as a live thing that can be improved, pruned, or removed when it stops serving users.

Core principles

- All content should answer a real question or help complete a task.
- Decisions are based on research and audience - not internal preference.
- Words are not always the answer. Consider tables, checklists and visuals.
- Use words the audience uses, not jargon, brand or insider terminology.
- Unclear content erodes trust. Be consistent accurate and honesty.
- Content should be planned, reviewed, and retired - not forgotten.



UK bank holidays

England and Wales | Scotland | Northern Ireland

The next bank holiday in England and Wales is

3 April

Good Friday

Upcoming bank holidays in England and Wales

2026

Date	Day of the week	Bank holiday
3 April	Friday	Good Friday
6 April	Monday	Easter Monday
4 May	Monday	Early May bank holiday
25 May	Monday	Spring bank holiday
31 August	Monday	Summer bank holiday
25 December	Friday	Christmas Day
28 December	Monday	Boxing Day (substitute day)

Related content

Holiday entitlement

School term and holiday dates

Home > Visas and immigration > What you need to do

Check if you need a UK visa

You may need a visa to come to the UK to visit, study or work.

Depending on your nationality, you may need to get an electronic travel authorisation (ETA).

> Find out about the visas you can get if you or your family member is from Ukraine.

Start now >

Related content

How to apply for a visa to come to the UK

Prove you have right of abode in the UK

Tax if you come to the UK

Collection

eVisa support videos

Travel or do business in Europe: Brexit guidance

Explore the topic

Commonwealth citizens and British nationals (overseas)

EU, EEA and Swiss citizens

Family in the UK

Study in the UK

Travelling to the UK

Show 3 more

How website owners apply this

- Before writing, ask: what does the user need to know or do here?
- Look for evidence - search queries, customers questions or analytics.
- Use plain language; avoid jargon and provide meaningful headings.
- Choose the simplest format. If a list works better than prose, use a list.
- Remove or update content that is rarely visited or no longer relevant.
- When in doubt, cut. Short and clear tends to perform better.

make it happen

References

1. Content Design by Sarah Richards (Winters) - the founding text of the discipline, short and practical
2. GOV.UK Content Design Guidance - the publicly available guide used to build and maintain one of the world's largest user-centred websites
3. Content Design London - resources, research, and the Readability Guidelines
4. Why Meta moved from content strategy to content design - a first-hand account from their Head of Content Design
5. GOV.UK Writing for the Web - practical plain language and formatting guidance
6. YouTube interview with Sarah Richards
7. UX Mastery interview with Sarah Richards